Blue wave makes Trump a lame duck

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Democrats outperformed our expectations in Senate and House races and clinched an unexpected victory in the Texas gubernatorial race, with the geographic diversity of the wins and large House margin likely to empower the moderate core of the party.
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President Donald Trump remains likely to escalate in Iran (65% odds), and will continue to engage with Russia, seeing both as legacy issues that now carry little political downside risk.
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Limiting Trump’s executive powers is likely beyond the reach of even the larger-than-expected Democratic majorities in Congress, but flipping Midwestern and Southern states could lead to a break between the White House and larger factions of the party.

Results likely to empower Democratic moderates. Abdul El-Sayed’s win in Michigan will be held up as proof that far-left candidates are electable in key states, though the results from last night seem more likely to benefit moderates within the party. Wins across the Midwest and South mean the party is now more geographically diverse, and the large House margin will allow party leaders to isolate the Democratic Socialists.

The open question is where this leaves Trump with his own party. Trump focused his early criticism on Republican candidates themselves, assigning blame for losses to failures in voter outreach. Losing both sizable margins in Congress and the Texas governor's seat—a Republican stronghold if ever there was one—are going to be difficult narratives to overcome and raise the chances GOP members will be willing to break with the White House.

Looking ahead to 2028, about 20% of GOP convention delegates hail from states that just flipped from red to blue. While primary voters are less likely than the average voter to moderate their views or break with Trump, the scale of states now theoretically on the board for a non-Trump candidate should be enough to keep such candidates’ hopes alive, especially if Trump’s popularity continues to decline.

With at least 54 Senate seats, Democrats will only need to flip six Republicans to clear the filibuster. That threshold is reachable for issues where Republicans have already demonstrated a willingness to

vote against Trump, such as the Iran war. This sets up the potential for bipartisan messaging votes (which Trump will veto) and clears a path for government funding in Congress. However, overcoming a two-thirds majority threshold in both chambers to override Trump's veto and block executive authorities remains unlikely, leaving most of Trump’s policies out of reach of Congressional action.

Impeaching Trump, or rather removing him from office, remains out of reach. The Senate needs 67 votes to remove Trump from office, meaning—as of now, with two races uncalled—13 GOP votes. The remaining GOP senators are, on average, more aligned with Trump following the departure of three more moderate members, and there is little upside for GOP members to put themselves above the parapet and vote to remove their own party’s leader in a presidential cycle.

On Iran, Trump will now be weighing the political costs of escalation against the reality that he has little left to lose, aligning with our view that escalation is likely around mid-November (see The US will likely strike Iran in mid-November , 27 October 2026). Frustration with the results last night could pull that forward, though the reality of military planning means there is a limit to how quickly the administration can decide to move.

Broadly, Trump will now be focused on securing his legacy. On Russia, he will remain in the thrall of a long-shot deal with President Vladimir Putin at the December G20 meeting in Miami and will keep diplomatic pressure on President Volodymyr Zelensky until he grows frustrated with the lack of progress with Putin. Trump will also lean into projects like the triumphal arch near Arlington National Cemetery, the redesign of East Potomac Golf Course, and efforts to name as many things after himself as possible.

For Vice President JD Vance and Secretary of State Marco Rubio, the results pose an awkward question: differentiate yourself from Trump and keep your 2028 chances alive, or try to hold on to Trump's base as your foundation for the primaries. Rubio, who has isolated himself from some of Trump's more unpopular decisions, likely still has the ability to move toward the former. Vance, as the serving vice president, is likely locked into the latter. Expect Rubio to lean into securing democratic elections in Venezuela and unseating the Castro regime in Cuba through economic pressure as he builds his resume of accomplishments in Latin America.

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